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2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Paper 2

Composition Pack

Everything students need for Section B: descriptive and narrative toolkits, 20 exam-style titles, planning sheets, a sentence-upgrade workshop and four annotated model compositions.

- ◆ Descriptive writing toolkit
- ◆ Narrative writing toolkit
- ◆ 20 exam-style titles in 5 sets
- ◆ 2 photocopiable planning sheets
- ◆ Sentence upgrade workshop
- ◆ 4 annotated model compositions
- ◆ Marking bands (40 marks)
- ◆ Self-assessment checklist

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How to use this pack

In Section B of Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 2, candidates choose **one** of four titles: two descriptive and two narrative. They write about 350–450 words. There is no reading text, so every mark is for writing.

Strand	What examiners look for	Marks
Content & structure	Ideas that are engaging and developed; a clear, deliberate structure; paragraphs that build an effect	16
Style & accuracy	Precise, ambitious vocabulary; varied sentences; control of tense and punctuation; accurate spelling and grammar	24

Descriptive or narrative?

Descriptive	Creates a vivid picture and atmosphere . Little or no plot. The biggest mistake is turning it into a story.
Narrative	Tells a story with one central event, a small cast and a satisfying ending. The biggest mistake is too much plot and too little feeling.

A sequence that works

Lesson 1	Descriptive toolkit → Upgrade workshop → Plan a descriptive title from Set 1
Lesson 2	Read a descriptive model → Write the Set 1 descriptive piece → Self-assess with the checklist
Lesson 3	Narrative toolkit → Plan a narrative title from Set 1 using the story mountain
Lesson 4	Read a narrative model → Write the piece → Peer-mark with the bands
Then	Sets 2–5 for timed practice: 10 minutes planning, 45 minutes writing, 5 minutes checking

BEFORE YOU START: This pack uses the 16/24 split from recent 0500 composition marking. Check the split for 2027 in the current syllabus. The bands in this pack are written for practice marking and are not official Cambridge descriptors.

Descriptive writing toolkit

A five-part structure

1 Wide view	Establish the place, time and mood in a few strong sentences.
2 Zoom in	Focus closely on one small, specific detail: an object, a texture, a sound.
3 Person or movement	Bring in a figure or some motion to give the scene life, without starting a plot.
4 Shift	Change something: time passes, the weather turns, the light fades, the mood alters.
5 Return	Go back to the wide view, now changed. Echo your opening.

Techniques that lift a description

- **Use all five senses**, and make them specific: not “a nice smell”, but “cardamom and diesel”.
- **Precise nouns and verbs** do more than adjectives: “the shutters *rattled*” beats “the very loud shutters”.
- **One controlling image** (e.g. the market as a sleeping animal) holds the piece together.
- **Vary sentences**: a one-line paragraph for impact; long, flowing sentences for movement.
- **Contrast**: light/dark, noise/silence, past/present.
- **Present tense** creates immediacy. Whichever tense you choose, keep it consistent.

Avoid

Plot creep	If a crime, chase or rescue appears, you are writing a story.
Cliché	“Blood-red sun”, “deafening silence”, “the wind howled like a wolf”.
Adjective piles	“The dark, gloomy, scary, eerie house”: choose one precise word instead.
Lists of senses	“I could see... I could hear... I could smell...” Weave the senses in naturally.

Narrative writing toolkit

The story mountain

1 Hook	Start in the middle of something: an action, a line of dialogue, a strange detail.
2 Context	Who, where, and what the character wants. Keep backstory short.
3 Complication	Something goes wrong or changes. Tension rises.
4 Climax	The turning point. Slow it down: this is where the detail belongs.
5 Resolution	Show how things have changed. A reflective, circular or twist ending.

Four ways to open

Dialogue	"Don't open it," she said, but I already had.
Action	The ferry lurched, and my suitcase slid across the deck towards the rail.
Strange detail	The letter was shorter than I remembered, and the handwriting was enormous.
Short statement	Nobody believed me about the lake.

Craft essentials

- **Show, don't tell:** not "I was scared" but "My hand froze on the door handle."
- **One central event, two or three characters.** 450 words is not a novel.
- **Build tension** with short sentences, delay and sensory focus at the key moment.
- **Dialogue:** new speaker, new line; punctuation inside the speech marks; use it sparingly.
- **An object** that returns at the end (a candle, a letter, a key) gives shape and meaning.
- **Avoid** "it was all a dream", rushed endings and action with no feeling.

20 exam-style titles

Section B • Composition • 40 marks • about 1 hour. Answer **one** question from the set. Write about **350 to 450 words**. Marks are awarded for content and structure and for style and accuracy. Spend about 10 minutes planning.

Practice Set 1

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a busy airport arrivals hall late at night. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a place in the moments before a storm breaks. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story that begins: 'Nobody noticed when the lights went out.' [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story called 'The Return'. [40]

Practice Set 2

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a market as it closes at the end of the day. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe an elderly person's hands, and what they reveal about the life they have lived. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story about a secret that should never have been told. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story that ends with the words: '...and I never went back.' [40]

Practice Set 3

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe the view from a high place at dawn. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a school building during the summer holidays, when it is empty. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story about a journey that did not go as planned. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story called 'The Letter'. [40]

20 exam-style titles (continued)

Practice Set 4

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a crowded beach in summer, and then the same beach on a winter morning. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a kitchen in which a family meal is being prepared. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story in which a character has to make a difficult choice. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story that begins with a knock at the door. [40]

Practice Set 5

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a train station as a long-distance train departs. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a garden that has been abandoned for many years. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story about a competition. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story called 'The Last Day'. [40]

HOW TO CHOOSE IN THE EXAM: Spend one minute on each title. Pick the one where you can already see a place or a moment, not the one with the most exciting plot. A simple idea written with control scores more than an ambitious one that runs out of time.

Descriptive planning sheet

Title			
Place & time		Mood	
Controlling image			

Five-part structure

1 Wide view	
2 Zoom in	
3 Person / movement	
4 Shift	
5 Return, changed	

Senses bank

Sight		Sound	
Smell		Touch / taste	

Five ambitious words I will use: _____ · _____ · _____ · _____ · _____

Narrative planning sheet

Title			
Main character		Wants / fears	
Setting		Central event	

Story mountain

1 Hook	
2 Context	
3 Complication	
4 Climax (slow down)	
5 Resolution	

First line	
Last line	
Returning object	

Sentence upgrade workshop

Each sentence below is accurate but flat. Rewrite it so that it would impress an examiner. Aim to **show** rather than tell, use precise nouns and verbs, and bring in at least one sense.

Flat sentence	Your upgrade
1 The sun was very hot.	
2 I was very nervous before the race.	
3 The forest was dark and scary.	
4 There were lots of people at the station.	
5 Suddenly there was a loud noise.	
6 She was old and kind.	
7 It was a nice day at the beach.	
8 In conclusion, it was the best day of my life.	

Model upgrades

One possible upgrade for each sentence, with the technique it shows. Accept any version that uses the technique well.

- 1 *The sun pressed down on the car roofs until the metal ticked and shimmered.*
Show the heat through its effects; use precise verbs.
- 2 *My legs felt borrowed. I retied my laces for the third time, just to have something to do with my hands.*
Show, don't tell: reveal the feeling through the body and actions.
- 3 *Beneath the pines, the daylight thinned to a green dusk, and every snapped twig sounded like a footstep.*
Build atmosphere with light and sound instead of labelling it.
- 4 *Travellers poured from the escalators in a tide of suitcases, elbows and hurried apologies.*
Use a controlling metaphor and a list of specific nouns.
- 5 *The crash came from the kitchen – a single, splintering note, and then silence.*
Avoid "suddenly"; name the sound precisely; use a dash for impact.
- 6 *Her face was creased like a well-read letter, and she never let anyone leave her house without something wrapped in foil.*
Characterise through a fresh simile and a typical action.
- 7 *The sea lay flat and glittering, and the air smelled of salt, sun cream and frying fish.*
Replace vague adjectives with sensory detail.
- 8 *Even now, when I smell charcoal smoke, I am back on that rooftop, twelve years old, the whole city spread beneath me like a promise.*
End with a sensory memory, not a summary.

TRY THIS: Choose one paragraph of your last composition. Find the three flattest sentences and upgrade them using the techniques above.

Describe a market as it closes at the end of the day.

From Practice Set 2 • a top-band response (361 words). Read it after planning your own answer. It shows one strong way to answer the title, not the only one.

At six o'clock the light changes. The sun, which has hammered the market all afternoon, slides behind the minaret and leaves the lanes in a soft, honey-coloured haze, as though the whole place has breathed out.

The noise changes too. The fierce bargaining of midday has gone; in its place come the smaller sounds of an ending. Metal shutters rattle down one by one. Crates scrape across concrete. Somewhere a radio plays an old love song, half-drowned by the hiss of a hose washing fish scales into the gutter, where they glitter like spilled sequins.

At the fruit stall, Abu Karim is dismantling his last pyramid of the day, lifting down the bruised mangoes and split figs and setting them aside in a cardboard box. His hands are quick and brown and scarred, and they never hesitate: he knows the weight of every fruit without looking. A thin cat watches from beneath the table, its tail twitching, patient as a tax collector.

Further along, the spice sellers are folding their sacks. Each fold releases a ghost of what was sold – cumin, cardamom, a sharp breath of dried lime – so that walking down the lane is like turning the pages of a recipe book. A boy sweeps turmeric dust into the air, where it hangs, glowing, in the last slanting beams of light.

People drift away. A woman balances a sack of rice on one hip and a sleeping toddler on the other. Two old men who have argued about football at the same table for thirty years shake hands solemnly, knowing they will meet again tomorrow at nine.

By seven, the lanes are almost empty. The stalls stand bare and skeletal, their awnings rolled up like closed eyelids. Only the smell remains, rich and layered, clinging to the walls as though the market refuses to leave entirely. Then the street lamps flicker on, one after another, laying circles of orange light on the wet stones.

The cat slips out from under the table, takes the fish head someone has left for it, and vanishes into the dark. The market is asleep. Tomorrow, before the sun, it will wake again.

What makes it work

- **Structure:** moves from a wide view (light) to sound, zooms in on one person, widens again, then shifts in time (six to seven o'clock) and ends with a return to stillness.
- **Senses:** sight, sound, smell and touch are all used, and the smells in paragraph 4 are specific (cumin, cardamom, dried lime) rather than general.
- **Imagery:** fresh similes ("patient as a tax collector", "like turning the pages of a recipe book") instead of clichés.
- **No plot:** people move and act, but nothing "happens". The piece stays descriptive, as the task requires.
- **Cohesion:** the cat appears in paragraph 3 and returns at the end, giving a satisfying shape.

Describe a school building during the summer holidays, when it is empty.

From Practice Set 3 · a top-band response (368 words). Read it after planning your own answer. It shows one strong way to answer the title, not the only one.

In August, the school belongs to the heat.

The gates are chained. Beyond them, the playground stretches out, pale and blinding, its painted lines faded to the ghosts of old games. Nothing moves except the air above the tarmac, which trembles like water. A single forgotten water bottle lies by the fence, warped into a strange, melted shape by weeks of sun.

Inside, the corridors hold their breath. Without the stampede of feet and the shriek of the bell, the silence is so complete that the building seems larger, as if it has stretched out to rest. The only sounds are the tired hum of a drinks machine near the canteen and the occasional tick of metal expanding in the heat.

The classrooms are strange without their students. Chairs have been stacked upside-down on the desks, their legs pointing at the ceiling like the limbs of dead insects. Sunlight squeezes through the blinds and lies across the floor in thin stripes, and in each stripe the dust drifts and turns, slow and golden, the only thing in the room that still seems alive.

In Room 14, someone has forgotten to clean the whiteboard. Half a sentence remains in faded blue marker: *The main theme of the poem is*. The rest has been wiped away by a careless sleeve, and the sentence hangs there, unfinished, waiting for an answer that will not come until September.

On the walls, the displays are curling at the edges. A poster of the water cycle has slipped from one of its pins and hangs at an angle, as if it too has given up for the summer. A row of self-portraits by eleven-year-olds – wild orange hair, enormous smiles, eyes that do not quite match – gaze out at nobody, their bright colours already fading like the memory of a noisier time.

Late in the afternoon, the caretaker crosses the courtyard with a jangling ring of keys, the only person in the whole enormous building. He tests a door, checks a window, and pauses to look at the empty playground, as if listening for something. Then he locks the gate behind him, and the school settles back into its long, patient sleep.

What makes it work

- **Opening:** a short, striking one-sentence paragraph establishes mood at once.
- **Personification** (“the corridors hold their breath”) makes the building feel alive but sleeping, a controlling idea that returns in the final line.
- **Precise detail:** the unfinished sentence on the whiteboard is a small, specific image that suggests absence far better than “it was empty”.
- **Contrast:** the imagined noise of term time sharpens the silence of the holidays.
- **Sentence variety:** short sentences (“The gates are chained.”) alongside long, flowing ones.

Write a story that begins: ‘Nobody noticed when the lights went out.’

From Practice Set 1 • a top-band response (383 words). Read it after planning your own answer. It shows one strong way to answer the title, not the only one.

Nobody noticed when the lights went out.

My mother was scrolling through work emails, my brother was hunched over a game, and I was rewriting the same message to Lina for the fourth time. Our screens glowed on, bright and faithful, and it was a full minute before my brother looked up and said, ‘Why’s it so dark?’

Outside, the storm had finally arrived. Rain lashed the windows of Grandpa’s flat and the whole street had vanished into blackness. Then the Wi-Fi died, and one by one our phones followed, until the only sound was the old clock on the bookcase – a sound I had never noticed in fourteen years of visits.

That was when I realised Grandpa’s chair was empty.

Since his illness began, Grandpa had become almost a piece of furniture. He sat by the window in his cardigan, smiling politely at us as though we were strangers. Some days he called me by my mother’s name. Some days he called me nothing at all.

‘Grandpa?’ My voice sounded thin in the dark.

We found him in the kitchen. Somehow he had found a candle and lit it, and he was standing at the counter, his face glowing gold, his hands steady, pouring tea into four glasses.

‘Sit,’ he said. ‘When the lights go, you sit together. That is the rule.’

So we sat, and in the small circle of candlelight he began to talk. He told us about his village, where the electricity failed every summer and his mother told stories until the children fell asleep. He told us about meeting my grandmother at a wedding where the generator broke and everyone danced to a single drum. He laughed – a real laugh, one I had forgotten he owned.

Then he looked straight at me. ‘Yasmin,’ he said. ‘You have your grandmother’s eyes.’

It was the first time he had said my name in a year.

The lights came back at half past eleven. The fridge shuddered into life and our phones began to buzz. When I looked back at Grandpa, the brightness had already drained from his face.

I kept the candle. Some nights, I switch off my lamp and light it, and for a few minutes I am back in that kitchen, and he knows my name.

What makes it work

- **Hook:** uses the given opening, then immediately shows why nobody noticed (the screens), turning the line into a theme.
- **One central event, few characters:** the whole story happens in one evening in one flat.
- **Complication:** the empty chair creates tension and a turning point.
- **Show, don’t tell:** Grandpa’s illness is shown through what he calls people, not explained in medical terms.
- **Climax in a single line:** “You have your grandmother’s eyes.” A short paragraph follows to let it land.
- **Ending:** the candle is an object that carries the meaning forward. The ending is reflective, and neither rushed nor explained.

Write a story called ‘The Letter’.

From Practice Set 3 • a top-band response (369 words). Read it after planning your own answer. It shows one strong way to answer the title, not the only one.

The letter was shorter than I remembered, and the handwriting was enormous.

On the last day of Year 11, Mr Hadid dragged the time capsule out of the storeroom and handed out the envelopes, reading our names like a register. Around me, people were already laughing at their eleven-year-old selves. I opened mine carefully, as if it might explode.

Dear Future Me, it said, in purple gel pen. I hope you are still drawing every day. If you haven't told Dad yet that you want to be an artist, DO IT TODAY. Love, Me. P.S. Is Mimi the cat still alive?

Mimi was still alive. Nothing else in the letter was.

I had not drawn anything except diagrams of the heart in almost three years. When it was time to choose my subjects, Dad had spread the brochures across the kitchen table like playing cards and talked about security and ‘a real future’. He had worked two jobs for most of my life so that I could have exactly that. So I chose the sciences, and my sketchbooks went into a box under the bed.

I carried the letter home in my pocket, where it seemed to grow heavier with every step. Dad was in the kitchen, still in his work shirt, frying onions. He looked tired. He always looked tired.

I put the letter on the counter beside the chopping board and watched him read it. The onions hissed. He read it twice. Then, without a word, he turned off the cooker and left the room.

My heart was hammering. I heard something heavy being dragged across the floor of the spare room. When he came back, he was holding a cardboard folder, soft and faded at the corners.

Inside were my drawings – the lopsided cats, the dragons, the portraits of him with an enormous moustache he had never actually had. He had kept every single one.

‘I thought you’d stopped because you wanted to,’ he said quietly. ‘You should have told me.’

‘I’m telling you now,’ I said.

That evening, I pulled the box out from under my bed. I drew Dad at the kitchen table, reading a letter, and I gave him the moustache.

What makes it work

- **Opening:** begins with the object in the title and a small, intriguing detail (“the handwriting was enormous”).
- **Backstory in one paragraph:** the father’s sacrifice is explained quickly, so the reader understands the character’s dilemma.
- **Tension through delay:** the father leaves the room without speaking; short sentences (“The onions hissed.”) slow the moment.
- **Twist that grows from character:** the folder of drawings reverses what the narrator (and reader) expected.
- **Dialogue:** only three lines, each one doing real work.
- **Circular ending:** the moustache links back to the drawings, ending with warmth and humour.

Marking guidance · Composition

These bands are written for this pack to support consistent practice marking. They follow the published assessment objectives but are not official Cambridge descriptors. Mark each strand separately, then add them together.

Content & structure 16 marks

14–16	Highly engaging, original ideas, fully developed. Structure is deliberate and controlled: a descriptive piece builds a sustained atmosphere; a narrative has well-managed tension and a satisfying ending.
11–13	Interesting, well-developed ideas; clear, effective structure; paragraphs build an overall effect.
7–10	Relevant ideas with some development; a recognisable structure; descriptive pieces may drift into plot, or narratives may be rushed at the end.
4–6	Simple ideas; limited development; structure is loose or list-like.
1–3	Very limited ideas; little sense of organisation.

Style & accuracy 24 marks

21–24	Precise, ambitious vocabulary used with control; sentences varied for deliberate effect; fresh imagery; almost error-free spelling, punctuation and grammar.
16–20	Effective vocabulary and some varied sentence structures; imagery mostly fresh; generally accurate with occasional slips.
11–15	Some good vocabulary choices; limited sentence variety; some clichés; errors present but meaning clear.
6–10	Plain vocabulary; repetitive sentences; frequent errors, including tense and sentence boundaries.
1–5	Errors often obscure meaning; very limited vocabulary.

Composition checklist & tracker

Descriptive

- ☐ No plot: atmosphere, not events
- ☐ Five-part structure with a shift
- ☐ At least four senses, specific
- ☐ One controlling image
- ☐ A one-line paragraph for impact
- ☐ Ending echoes the opening

Narrative

- ☐ Hook in the first line
- ☐ One central event, few characters
- ☐ Feelings shown, not told
- ☐ Climax slowed down with detail
- ☐ Dialogue punctuated correctly
- ☐ Ending not rushed

Both

- ☐ 350–450 words ☐ Consistent tense ☐ Varied sentence openings ☐ No clichés ☐ Paragraphs ☐ Proofread for full stops and commas

Score tracker

Set	Title chosen	Content & structure /16	Style & accuracy /24	Total /40
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

NEXT STEP

Complete your 0500 preparation

IGCSE 0500 Complete Exam Guide (2027): the method for every question on both papers.

Paper 1 Practice Pack: three full Paper 1 Reading practice papers with mark schemes.

Paper 2 Directed Writing Pack: four Section A tasks with annotated model answers.

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